SESSION PLAN

Attack with width and depth, Deny, Dictate and Keep

Men's 2nd XI · Wednesday 11 November

Team / age group	Men's 2nd XI	**Coach**	Head Coach
Date / time	Wednesday 11 November	**Venue / space**	Half pitch (three-quarter pitch for block 4)
Duration	70 mins	**Players**	12-14 outfield + 1 GK
Equipment	Balls x20, Cones (3 colours), Bibs x3 sets, Mini goals x4	**Session focus**	Blue (attack) are in the Attack phase with the ball to goal and switch to Dictate when they lose it. Red (defence) are in the Deny phase and switch to Keep when they win it.

SESSION OBJECTIVES

• Attack: hold width (both wide channels filled) and depth (one high, one supporting) on every entry to the 23 and finish at the back post
• Deny and Keep: defend the D as a unit, then on a turnover keep the ball and drive into the free space
• Dictate: on losing the ball, react within 5 seconds to force the opposition one way and win it back

KEY MESSAGES / TRIGGER WORDS

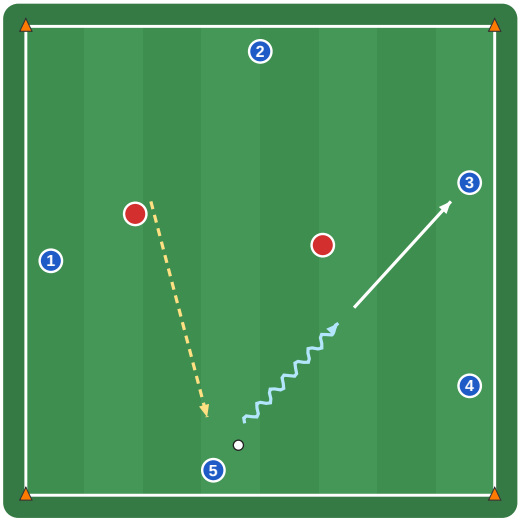
• Phase map - BLUE: Attack, lose it = Dictate. RED: Deny, win it = Keep
• "Chalk on boots" - wide players on the sideline
• "Stretch it" - someone high, someone short
• "Deny!" - protect the D, ball side and goal side
• "Keep it!" - first pass safe, then drive into space
• "Dictate!" - nearest man presses, show them one way

SESSION OVERVIEW

Time	Block	Mins
0–10	**Warm-up** Rondo 5v2: keep it, split it, drive it	10
10–30	**Technical** Width and depth waves v a Deny unit	20
30–50	**Small-sided** 6+1 v 6 + GK: Attack and Dictate v Deny and Keep	20
50–70	**Live game scenario** 7v7 live: Attack/Dictate v Deny/Keep	20

DIAGRAM KEY

1. WARM-UP: Rondo 5v2: keep it, split it, drive it — 0–10 min (10')



Two grids side by side (x2). 5 keep the ball against 2. When a presser commits, drive into the space he has left.

ORGANISATION / SET-UP

Two 15x15m grids, 7 per grid (5 outside, 2 pressers inside). With 12 players run 4v2. Balls stocked at each corner.

ADAPT IT (STEP)

S Space: Make the grid longer than it is wide to show more space to drive into
P People: 4v2 with 12 players, 5v2 with 14

BLUE LOSE IT: DICTATE PHASE

• New pressers go within 2 seconds of losing it, no sulking
• First presser curves his run to show the ball one way, second cuts the pass

RED WIN IT: KEEP PHASE

• On winning it: first pass to your partner or carry it out, never a hopeful hit

HOW IT WORKS

• Outside players keep the ball, two-touch limit.
• Pass that splits the two pressers = 1 point. Drive into the space a presser has left, then pass out = 2 points.
• Pressers win it: they must make 1 pass to each other or dribble out of the grid (Keep) before they swap in.
• Losing player and his passer become the new pressers straight away (Dictate).

LINK TO THEME

Introduces all four phases in one small game: keep and drive with the ball, press as a pair without it, secure the ball on a turnover.

COACHING POINTS

• Open body on receive to see both pressers before the ball arrives
• Presser steps towards you = space behind him: carry the ball into it
• Drive at pace with the head up, then release early
• Off the ball: make an angle either side of the ball carrier

PROGRESSIONS (HARDER)

• One-touch unless you are driving
• Shrink to 12x12m

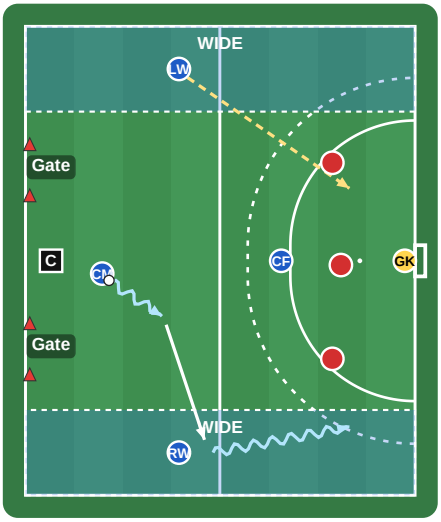
REGRESSIONS (EASIER)

• Three touches allowed
• Pressers at 50% pace for the first two minutes

KEEPING EVERYONE ACTIVE

All 12-14 working in two grids, nobody waiting. Pressers rotate on every turnover or every 60 seconds.

2. TECHNICAL: Width and depth waves v a Deny unit — 10–30 min (20')



Blue waves of 4 attack with width and depth. Red 3 + GK Deny. Red win it: Keep and drive out through a gate on halfway. Blue lose it: Dictate.

ORGANISATION / SET-UP

Half pitch with GK. Wide channels coned 10m in from each sideline. 2 gates (6m wide) on halfway. Blue: two waves of 4 (CM, RW, LW, CF). Red: 3 defenders + GK, with 2-3 more red resting. Swap blue and red at 10 minutes.

BLUE LOSE IT: DICTATE PHASE

- Nearest blue presses the ball straight away, curved run to show it away from the gates
- Other blues cut the passes to the gates, don't all chase the ball
- 5 seconds then reset: don't get dragged out of shape

RED DEFENCE: DENY PHASE

- Protect the D first: goal side and ball side
- Push the wide player down the line, then stop the cross with the stick on the ground
- Far-side defender tucks in to mark the back post, don't ball-watch

RED WIN IT: KEEP PHASE

- First pass is safe and away from pressure
- Look up: if a blue has committed, drive into the space he left and out through a gate

HOW IT WORKS

- Minutes 0-4 unopposed: coach feeds CM, CM drives, plays wide, wide player drives to the baseline and crosses to the CF (near post) or far winger (back post).
- Minutes 4-10 live: red 3 + GK Deny. Blue score = 1, from a wide channel cross = 2.
- Red win it: Keep phase, dribble or pass through a gate on halfway = 1 point. Blue lose it: Dictate phase, 5 seconds to win it back.
- Next blue wave goes as soon as a rep ends. Red rotate one defender out every 3 reps. Swap teams at 10 minutes and repeat.

LINK TO THEME

Full walkthrough of the Attack phase, now against a defence in Deny, with the turnover moments (Dictate and Keep) built into every rep.

COACHING POINTS

- Wide players: chalk on boots, stay wide until the ball is played to you
- CF stays high to pin the defence: that is the space the CM drives into
- Wide receiver goes to the baseline, not across the D
- Far-side winger arrives late at the back post, not early

QUESTIONS TO ASK

- What happens to their defence if both our wingers come inside?
- Red: where do you want the blue winger to go?

PROGRESSIONS (HARDER)

- Add a 4th red defender recovering from halfway
- Blue CF can double lead and the CM plays in behind

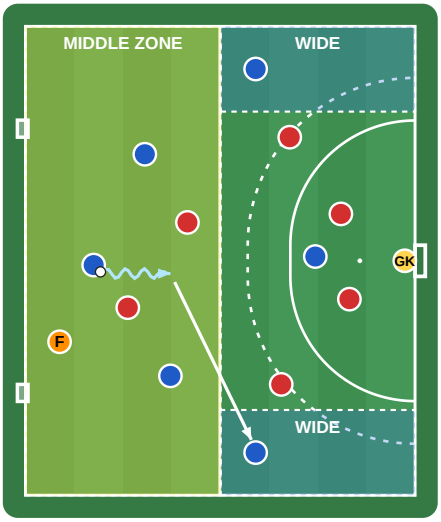
REGRESSIONS (EASIER)

- Red 2 + GK only
- Red play at 50% for the first 2 minutes of live

KEEPING EVERYONE ACTIVE

Two blue waves alternate, so rest is one rep (about 30 seconds). Red resting players collect balls and rotate in every 3 reps, so nobody waits more than a minute.

3. SMALL-SIDED: 6+1 v 6 + GK: Attack and Dictate v Deny and Keep **30–50 min** (20')



Blue (+ orange floater) attack the full goal with width and depth. Red Deny, then on a win Keep and score in a mini goal on halfway.

ORGANISATION / SET-UP

Half pitch. Wide channels 10m in from each sideline inside the 23. Blue 6 + 1 floater attack the full goal. Red 6 + GK defend and counter to 2 mini goals on halfway. With 12 players go 5+1 v 5. Swap blue and red every 5 minutes (4 rounds).

ADAPT IT (STEP)

S Space: Widen the channels to 12m to make width easier to find
T Task: Bonus point for any drive that beats a player
P People: Floater changes every role swap

BLUE LOSE IT: DICTATE PHASE

• Closest player presses, the next two cut the nearest passes
• Show the red player towards the sideline, away from the mini goals
• Floater drops to cover the middle so we aren't exposed

RED DEFENCE: DENY PHASE

• Stay compact: no gap bigger than 10m between defenders
• Show the attack wide and away from the D, then stop the cross
• Communicate: one voice organises the back line

RED WIN IT: KEEP PHASE

• First pass out of pressure, then drive into the space the blue press has left
• Width in the keep: a red player goes wide straight away to stretch their Dictate press

HOW IT WORKS

• Every rep starts with a coach feed to blue on halfway.
• Blue (Attack): in the 23 they need a player in each wide channel and one high. Goal = 1, goal from a ball played in from a wide channel = 2.
• Red (Deny): stop the goal. Win it and switch to Keep: 5 passes = 1 point, or score in a mini goal = 1 point.
• Blue lose it (Dictate): win it back inside 6 seconds = 1 bonus point. Floater always plays for blue.

LINK TO THEME

Both teams live through all four phases on every turnover: Attack, Dictate, Deny and Keep.

COACHING POINTS

• Before the ball goes into the 23: are both channels filled, is someone high?
• If it isn't on, recycle through the floater and switch, don't force it
• Wide receiver: first touch forward down the line
• Back post filled on every wide entry

QUESTIONS TO ASK

• Blue: how did their Deny shape change when our wingers stayed wide?
• Red: what was the best moment to drive after winning it?

PROGRESSIONS (HARDER)

• Remove the floater (6v6)
• Red only need 3 passes, blue only get 4 seconds to win it back

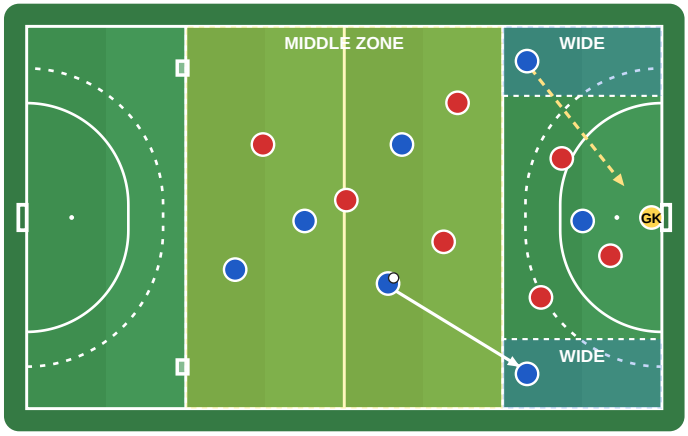
REGRESSIONS (EASIER)

• Floater also plays for red when they win it
• No Dictate bonus, blue just reset at halfway

KEEPING EVERYONE ACTIVE

13-14 players all involved, no queue. Coach has balls ready at halfway for an instant restart after each attack ends. Drinks at each role swap.

4. LIVE GAME SCENARIO: 7v7 live: Attack/Dictate v Deny/Keep — 50–70 min (20')



Left 23 to right backline. Blue attack the full goal with width and depth (Attack), red Deny and on a win Keep and attack 2 wide mini goals on the 23. Swap at 10 minutes.

ORGANISATION / SET-UP

Three-quarter pitch: left 23m line to the right backline. Wide channels inside the attacking 23. GK in the full goal, 2 mini goals in the wide channels on the 23m line. 7v7 (6v6 with 12). Swap roles at 10 minutes.

BLUE LOSE IT: DICTATE PHASE

- Press as a unit, not one man chasing
- Show them inside where our numbers are, away from the wide mini goals
- If the press is broken, recover goal side and reset

RED DEFENCE: DENY PHASE

- Hold the shape in the D, defend the back post
- Pressure the wide player early to stop the cross

RED WIN IT: KEEP PHASE

- Patience: switch the ball to the side blue have left open, then drive into it
- Spread wide and deep straight away so blue can't press everyone

HOW IT WORKS

- Blue attack the full goal: goal = 1, goal from a ball played in from a wide channel = 2.
- Red Deny, then on a win Keep: goal in a mini goal after 5+ passes = 2, otherwise 1.
- Blue win it back within 6 seconds of losing it = 1 point.
- Ball out or goal: coach feeds a new ball straight in. No waiting for players to get back.

LINK TO THEME

All four phases at match tempo over a bigger area, so the switch between them has to happen as it would on Saturday.

COACHING POINTS

- Attack: width before you enter, depth beyond the ball
- Wide channel ball: drive to the baseline, cross early and low to the back post
- Recognise the moment: ball lost = Dictate straight away
- Score: keep a running total of each team's points across both halves

PROGRESSIONS (HARDER)

- Wide channel goals worth 3
- Two-touch limit for red in the Keep phase

REGRESSIONS (EASIER)

- Add a neutral floater for the team in possession
- Remove the 5-pass bonus

KEEPING EVERYONE ACTIVE

Everyone plays for all 20 minutes. Quick coach restarts keep the ball in play. Drinks at the 10-minute swap.

POST-SESSION REFLECTION

What went well against today's objectives?	
Which players stood out / need follow-up?	
What would I change next time (space, numbers, timings)?	
Carry-over theme for next session:	

SAFETY / WELFARE NOTES

- Shin guards and gum shields for all
- GK fully kitted for blocks 2-4
- No aerials in blocks 2-4; crosses must be kept low